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Fact Sheet: Leading Causes of Death Among VHA Users

October 2025

CSPEAR provides timely epidemiologic information on VA health care users. This fact sheet presents summary data to inform a broad community of VA leaders, investigators, and clinicians as they consider how best to address the needs of Veterans.

Introduction: *The leading causes of death* (COD) published annually by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC) National Center for Health Statistics (NCHS) provides a framework for identifying leading COD in the United States. This annual accounting of deaths allows the CDC to monitor trends, recognize emerging challenges, track the effectiveness of interventions, and make public health decisions that improve and save lives ([NVSS - Leading Causes of Death \(cdc.gov\)](#))¹. The objective of this work is to determine a national accounting of the leading COD among Veterans Health Administration (VHA) users to set priorities for health services research of the Veteran population.

Table 1. VHA Users Counts, %, Rates in 2019

	Deaths		VHA Users	Death Rate per 100,000
	n	%		
Overall	274,368	100.00%	9,047,481	3,033
Age 20-24	77	0.0%	162,606	47
Age 25-34	1,168	0.4%	890,958	131
Age 35-44	1,834	0.7%	1,005,948	182
Age 45-54	4,531	1.7%	1,135,030	399
Age 55-64	20,229	7.4%	1,492,835	1,355
Age 65-74	68,741	25.0%	2,445,805	2,811
Age 75-84	68,765	25.1%	1,154,680	5,955
Age 85+	109,023	39.7%	759,619	14,352
Female	6,412	2.3%	828,804	774
Male	267,956	97.7%	8,218,677	3,260
Cause of Death				
Heart Disease	72,531	26.4%	9,047,481	802
Cancers	58,453	21.3%	9,047,481	646
CLRD	18,648	6.8%	9,047,481	206
CeVD	12,986	4.7%	9,047,481	144
Accidents	11,053	4.0%	9,047,481	122
Alzheimer's	10,012	3.6%	9,047,481	111
Diabetes	9,289	3.4%	9,047,481	103
Kidney Disease	5,431	2.0%	9,047,481	60
Parkinson's	5,220	1.9%	9,047,481	58
Influenza	4,868	1.8%	9,047,481	54

Fast Facts

- 274,368 VHA users died in 2019. The mortality rate was 3,033 per 100,000 VHA users.
- Male mortality (3,260 per 100,000) was higher than that of females (774 per 100,000), likely due to differences in age distributions between sexes, with males skewing older.
- Heart disease (26%), cancer (21%), and chronic lower respiratory disease (7%) accounted for >50% of all deaths.
- Accidents and suicides dominated cause of death in younger age groups (<45 years) compared to older age groups where heart disease and cancer were the primary causes of death.
- Males had a much higher proportion of deaths due to accidents and suicide than females in the 25-44 age groups.
- Cancer was the leading cause of death in females, both overall and for all age groups except 25-34 and 85+
- There was a higher proportion of deaths from Alzheimer's disease in females vs males for ages 75-84 (7.3% vs 3.5% respectively) and for ages 85+ (10.6% vs 6.1% respectively).
- Heart disease was by far the most prevalent cause of death for males (30%) and females (27%) 85 years and older.

Abbreviations: CDC NCHS: Centers for Disease Control National Center for Health Statistics; Cancers: Malignant Neoplasms; CLRD: Chronic Lower Respiratory Disease; CeVD: Cerebrovascular Disease; Diabetes: Diabetes Mellitus; Influenza: Influenza & Pneumonia; Heart Dz: Diseases of the heart; CLD: Chronic Liver Disease and Cirrhosis

Methods:

Data were extracted from the Corporate Data Warehouse (CDW), a national database that integrates clinical and administrative information in the VHA. All VHA users were identified who had received any inpatient or outpatient care at a VHA facility any time during 2004 through 2018, were between 20 and 110 years old, had been assigned into 1 of the 8 VHA priority groups and were alive in 2019.

Dates of death and the underlying cause of death for Veterans who had died during that same period were received from the National Death Index (NDI) which provides mortality data from death certificates. Causes of death were grouped and ranked according to CDC NCHS developed phenotypes¹. Results are presented overall and by age and sex. Six cause of death categories were listed when the top five causes of death were different for males and females. Additional statistics are provided in the Supplement.

Visit [CSPEAR's website](#) or contact CSPEAR@va.gov for more information.

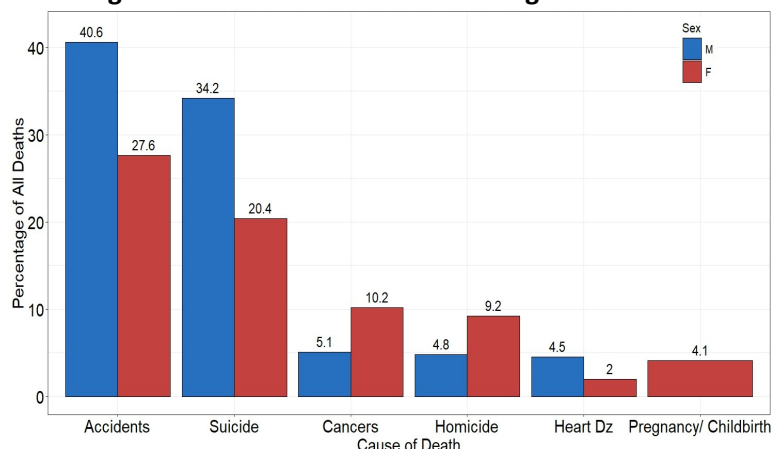
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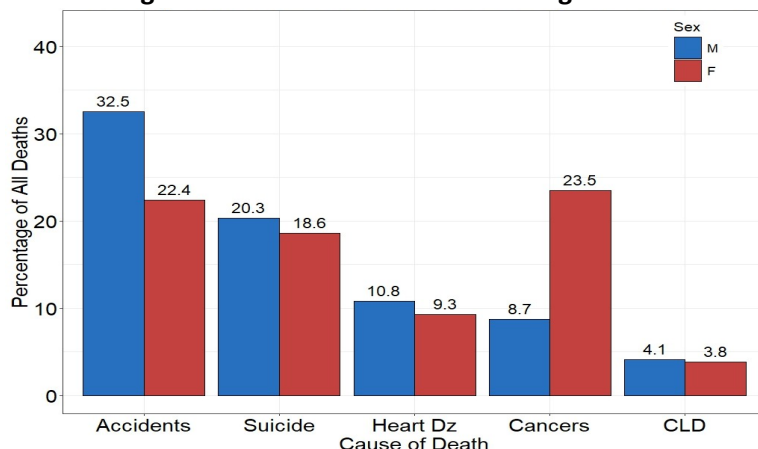
U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs
Veterans Health Administration
Cooperative Studies Program

Figure 1. Leading Causes of Death by Age Group, Sex

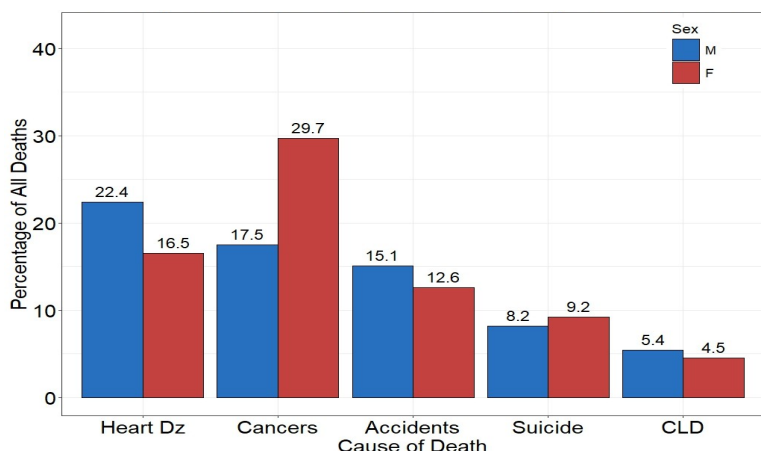
Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 25-34 in 2019



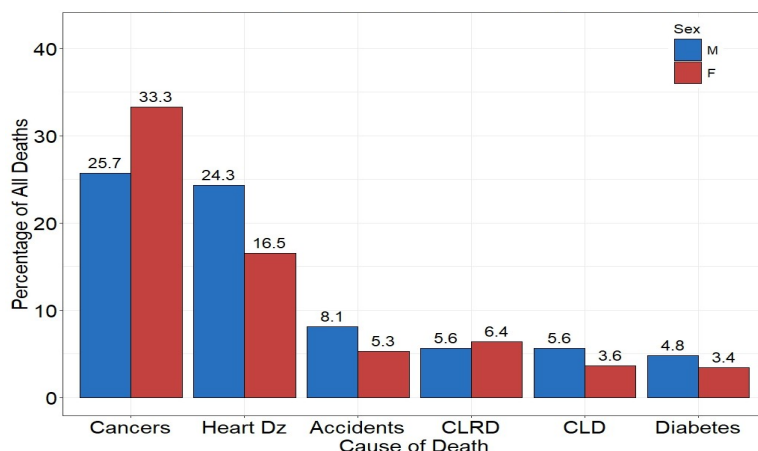
Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 35-44 in 2019



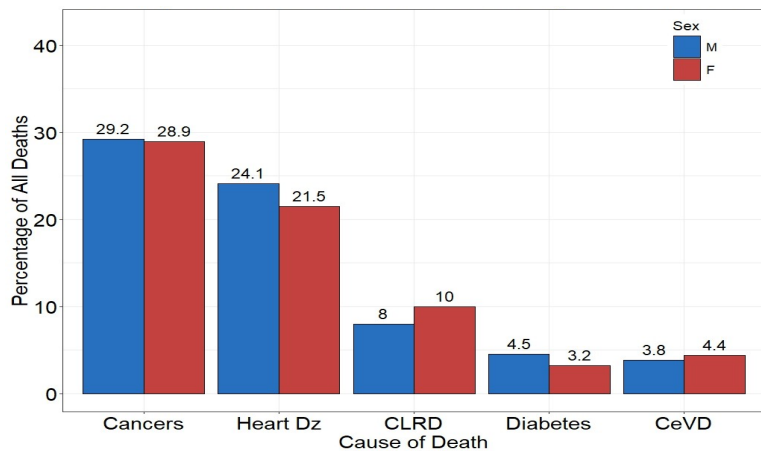
Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 45-54 in 2019



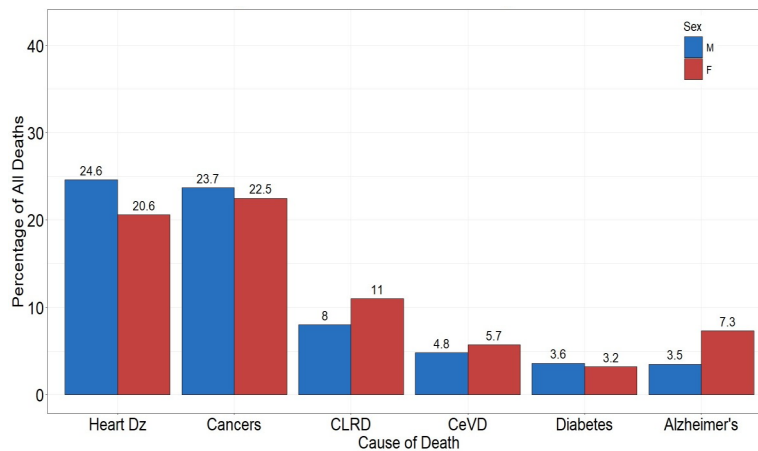
Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 55-64 in 2019



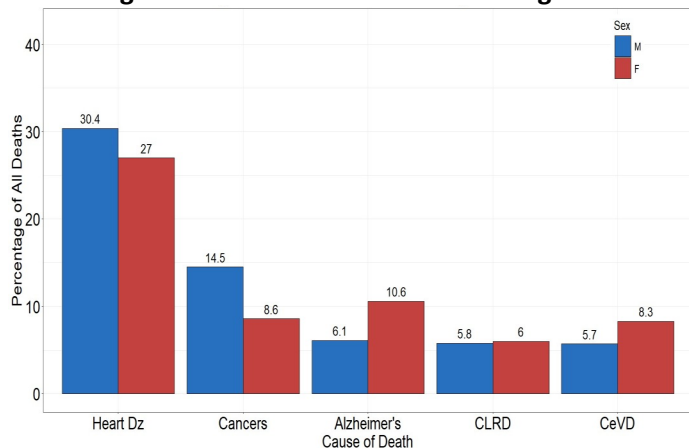
Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 65-74 in 2019



Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 75-84 in 2019



Leading Causes of Death for VHA Users Age 85+ in 2019



Notes: This work was conducted under CSPEAR's operational access to VA data. This material is the result of work supported with resources and the use of facilities at the VA Cooperative Studies Program Epidemiology Center in Boston, MA. The contents do not represent the views of VA or the US Government. Additional figures and information are provided in the Supplement.

References and Resources

1. Heron M. Deaths: Leading causes for 2019. National Vital Statistics Reports; vol 70 no 9. Hyattsville, MD: National Center for Health Statistics. 2021. DOI: <https://dx.doi.org/10.15620/>